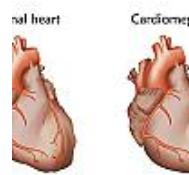


RECENT ARTICLES



**After ablation, exercise
may lower atrial fibrillation
recurrence**



**What can cause an
enlarged heart?**

EXERCISE AND FITNESS

Is it too late to save your posture?

Even if your posture has been a problem for years, it's possible to make improvements.

January 9, 2025

By **Heidi Godman**, Managing Director

Reviewed by **Anthony L. Komaroff, MD**, Editor in Chief, *Harvard Health Letter*; Editorial Advisory Board Member, Harvard Health Publishing



Rounded shoulders and a hunched stance may seem like they're set in stone by the time we reach a certain age, and you may feel you've missed the boat for better posture. But there's a good chance you can still stand up taller.

It's not as hard as you may think. Better posture is often just a matter of changing your activities and strengthening your muscles.

What causes posture problems?

Poor posture often stems from modern-day habits like working in front of a computer, slouching on a couch while watching TV, or looking down at a smartphone. Poor posture could also be due to many hours spent carrying heavy objects (like equipment at work, grocery bags, or a heavy purse).

You might also be interested in...



Exercise SHR Bundle

Staying active doesn't have to mean pushing too hard or risking injury. This carefully designed four-report Exercise Bundle is created specifically for older adults who want to maintain strength, flexibility, and confidence—without intimidation or confusion. Whether you're returning to exercise after time off or looking for a sustainable way to stay mobile, this bundle gives you guidance, structure, and encouragement in one complete package. No gym required. No pressure. Just practical tools to help you keep doing the things you love, with strength and confidence.

LEARN MORE

All of these activities can make you stoop or bring your shoulders forward. This overstretches and weakens the muscles in the back of your shoulders, and shortens the muscles in the front of your shoulders and in your chest. Gravity then pulls the muscles forward, because the muscles are too weak to pull them back up.

If the core muscles in your back and abdomen have grown weak from inactivity, that can also cause you to lean forward. Those muscles are crucial to lifting your frame and keeping you upright.

Another cause of poor posture, as we reported in September, comes from broken bones in your back. People with brittle bones ([osteoporosis](#)) may experience compression fractures when the bones in the back (vertebrae) aren't strong enough to support the load placed on them. The bone collapses on the front side, the part closest to the chest. As collapsed vertebrae stack up, the spine becomes rounded and bends forward, a condition called dowager's hump (dorsal kyphosis).

Poor posture consequences

Sometimes people ask, "Why should I change my posture? I don't mind it." But one of the big things that happens with forward posture is that your center of gravity goes forward. This increases the risk of falling. Poor [posture](#) can also cause back or [neck pain](#), headaches, trouble breathing, or trouble walking.

Move of the month: Seated chest stretch



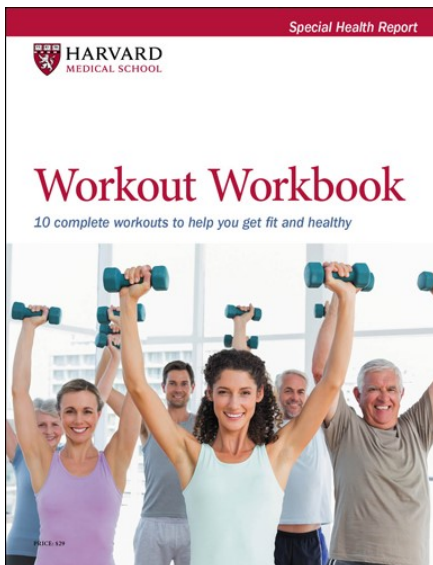
Sit up straight facing sideways in a chair. Clasp your hands behind you, locking your fingers so your palms face you. Lift your hands upward to the point of tightness. Hold 10 seconds and return to the starting position. Repeat two to four times.

Photo by Michael Carroll

Perk up your posture

If you have a spinal cord injury or you've had surgery to fuse or remove bones in your back, there may be some limitations to your posture improvement.

You might also be interested in...



Workout Workbook

The numbers are shocking. Just three out of 10 American adults are active enough to stay healthy and fit, and nearly four out of 10 admit they aren't active at all, despite reams of research proving that exercise is a powerful preventive, and sometimes an antidote, for disability and illness. Which side of this divide are you standing on — and why? Maybe you're not sure what blend of exercise is best. Or perhaps you know exactly what you need to do, but your workouts have become so humdrum that it's harder than ever to dig up the energy to do them. Do you want to jump-start your sputtering exercise program? Or are you stuck on a plateau and wishing you could kick it up to the next level?

LEARN MORE

Otherwise, it's usually not too late to correct posture, even if you've had broken vertebrae (once they've healed and your doctor says it's okay). In that case, we'd try to prevent fractures in other segments of your back. We can't change bones, but we can change muscle mass.

Tips to stand taller

The key to fixing poor posture is strengthening and stretching the muscles in the upper back, chest, and core.

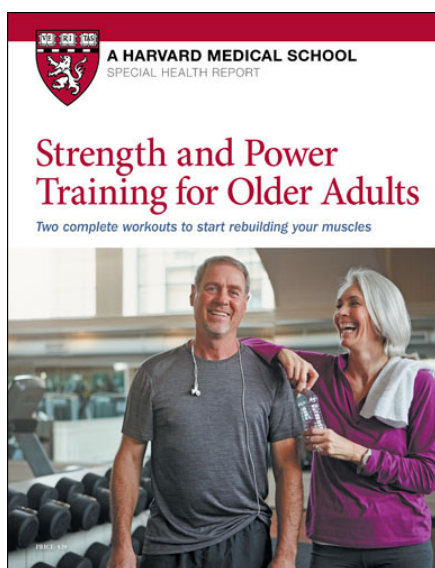
Shoulder strengtheners include scapula squeezes (squeezing your shoulder blades together for 30 seconds at a time) and rows (using a resistance band to pull back your elbows like you're

rowing).

Core strengtheners include modified planks (in which you hold a push-up position while propped up on your elbows) or simply tightening your abdominal muscles, pulling your navel in toward your spine.

An easy way to stretch your chest muscles: simply put your arms behind your back, grasp both elbows (or forearms if that's as far as you can reach), and hold the position.

You might be interested in...



Strength and Power Training for Older Adults: Two complete workouts to start rebuilding your muscles

Strength training isn't just for 20-somethings getting ready for the beach. Keeping your muscles strong and healthy is important for older adults, too. With strong muscles, you can enjoy a high quality of life for years to come – swinging your golf club, playing with your grandchildren, taking a walk in the woods, or hitting the dance floor. Strength and Power Training for Older Adults, a Special Health Report from the experts at Harvard Medical School, shows you the safest and most effective ways of strengthening your muscles – without spending a lot of time or money.

LEARN MORE

You'll also have to work on your posture in everyday activities. A simple trick when you're sitting (even watching TV): Put a rolled towel behind your shoulders. It makes you sit up straight so the towel won't fall.

Cut down on activities that have led to poor posture, too. Take breaks from computer and TV time, and exercise more.

About the Author



Heidi Godman, Managing Director

Heidi Godman directs all news gathering for Harvard Health Publishing, and also directs the curation and production of HHP's four monthly subscription publications (the Harvard Health Letter, Harvard Heart Letter, Harvard Men's Health Watch, and Harvard Women's Health ... [See Full Bio](#)

[View all posts by Heidi Godman](#)

About the Reviewer



Anthony L. Komaroff, MD, Editor in Chief, *Harvard Health Letter*; Editorial Advisory Board Member, Harvard Health Publishing

Dr. Anthony L. Komaroff is the Steven P. SimcoxPatrick A. Clifford/James H. Higby Distinguished Professor of Medicine at Harvard Medical School, senior physician at Brigham and Women's Hospital in Boston, and editor in chief of the ... [See Full Bio](#)

[View all posts by Anthony L. Komaroff, MD](#)

Disclaimer:

As a service to our readers, Harvard Health Publishing provides access to our library of archived content. Please note the date of last review or update on all articles.

No content on this site, regardless of date, should ever be used as a substitute for direct medical advice from your doctor or other qualified clinician.

Related Topics



**HEALTHY AGING
AND LONGEVITY**

**Why do I shrink in
height as I age?**



HEART HEALTH

**What is a normal heart
rate?**

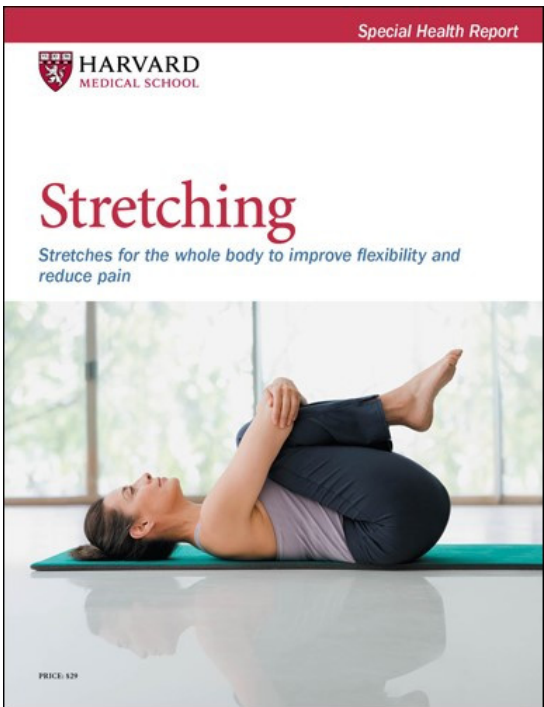


**EXERCISE AND
FITNESS**

**Foam rollers:
Inexpensive tools with
premium payoffs**

PHYSICAL ACTIVITY AND EXERCISE

You might also be interested in...



**Stretching: Stretches for the
whole body to improve
flexibility and reduce pain**

Stretching is an excellent thing you can do for your health. These simple yet effective moves can help you limber up for sports, improve your balance and prevent falls, increase your flexibility, and even help relieve arthritis, back, and knee pain. Whether you're an armchair athlete or a sports enthusiast, this Special Health Report, *Stretching: Stretches for the whole body to improve flexibility and reduce pain*, from the experts at Harvard Medical School will show you how to create effective stretching routines that meet your needs and ability.

READ MORE

FREE HEALTHBEAT SIGNUP

Get the latest in health news delivered to your inbox!

SIGN UP



© 2026 [Harvard Health Publishing®](#) of The President and Fellows of Harvard College

[Do not sell my personal information](#) | [Privacy Policy and Terms of Use](#)